THE GROUND

Yang–Mills Theory after the Alpöge–Sussman Manuscripts

What Is Constructed, What Is Claimed, and the Object That Remains

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Abstract

A proof that quantum Yang–Mills theory has a mass gap must stand on a construction of the theory, and the most complete public construction now in view is the corpus of manuscripts that Levent Alpöge and Ethan Sussman have posted since 6 October 2026, carrying Bałaban's renormalisation group from the lattice to the continuum for the gauge group SU(2). This paper fixes that ground. It reads the corpus from its primary sources and proves, clause by clause and with exact references, what the corpus asserts and at what strength. In three dimensions an 854-page manuscript asserts continuum Schwinger functions of the plaquette-energy density, the lattice form of tr F^2, which satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms in the clustering components of infinite-volume limits taken along subsequences, together with a short-distance law that makes the theory non-trivial; it asserts no mass gap. In four dimensions a 153-page draft deduces, from inputs it declares clause by clause and from supporting statements two of which are not yet written, continuum limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences with regularity, reflection positivity, symmetry and hypercubic invariance; its authors call the underlying argument extremely long and not understandable as it stands, and state that the corpus has not been satisfactorily vetted. The paper then proves that, for a reflection-positive theory, a mass gap is the same property as exponential clustering of the reflection-positive correlations, and that a lower bound on the lattice mass gap, uniform in physical units along the lattice sequence of such a construction, supplies at once the three

properties the corpus withholds: a unique vacuum, the cluster property and a mass gap. This identifies the object on which the proof that follows must stand.

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1. Introduction

The quantum Yang–Mills problem of the Clay Mathematics Institute is a single sentence. For every compact simple gauge group G it asks for a proof that a non-trivial quantum Yang–Mills theory exists on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and has a mass gap $\Delta > 0$.[1] The sentence joins two demands of different kinds. The first is a construction: a system of correlation functions, free of every cutoff, defined on the whole of space-time and obeying axioms at least as strong as those of Wightman and of Osterwalder and Schrader. The second is an inequality: the spectrum of the Hamiltonian of the theory so constructed must leave an interval above zero empty. The inequality cannot be stated before the construction exists, and when the construction proceeds by compactness, the problem's own text, in a footnote examined in Section 3, does not count it as complete until properties of this kind are proved for the limit.

In two dimensions the continuum Yang–Mills measure was constructed in 1989, by Driver and by Gross, King and Sengupta.[2] In three and in four dimensions Bałaban controlled Wilson's lattice theory on a torus by a renormalisation group whose bounds are uniform in the lattice spacing.[3] When the problem was posed, its authors wrote that a detailed construction on a compact space would be a major breakthrough, and that even then "no present ideas point the direction to establish the existence of a mass gap that is uniform in the volume. Nor do present methods suggest how to obtain the existence of the infinite volume limit $T^4 \to \mathbb{R}^4$."[4]

On 6 October 2026 Ethan Sussman opened a public repository for the joint work of Levent Alpöge and himself, whose stated aim is "to induce LLMs to develop, push, and extend Balaban's program to construct Yang--Mills_4 (YM4) and other quantum gauge theories".[5] It now holds an 854-page manuscript on three-dimensional SU(2) Yang–Mills theory, a revised edition of 856 pages, a 1,044-page sequel on curvature bilinears, a 263-page manuscript on three-dimensional quantum electrodynamics, a 30-page manuscript on rotation invariance from reflection positivity, and a 153-page zeroth draft on four-dimensional SU(2) Yang–Mills theory.[6] Peter Woit discussed the repository on 26 October 2026.[7] Its standing has since been compressed into a single sentence: a public three-dimensional manuscript proving the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms for tr F^2, about 854 pages, "LLM-approved", unverified, with subsequential infinite-volume limits and no gap; and a four-dimensional

[1] A. Jaffe and E. Witten, "Quantum Yang–Mills theory", official problem description of the Clay Mathematics Institute, https://www.claymath.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/06/yangmills.pdf, §4, p. 6.

[2] B. K. Driver, "YM_2: continuum expectations, lattice convergence, and lassos", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 123 (1989); L. Gross, C. King and A. Sengupta, "Two dimensional Yang–Mills theory via stochastic differential equations", *Ann. Physics* 194 (1989).

[3] T. Bałaban, "Ultraviolet stability of three-dimensional lattice pure gauge field theories", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 102 (1985), 255–275; "Renormalization group approach to lattice gauge field theories. I", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 109 (1987), 249–301; and the further papers of the series, *Comm. Math. Phys.* 95–122 (1984–1989).

[4] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6, p. 7.

[5] L. Alpöge and E. Sussman, README of the repository *Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment*, https://github.com/ethanwsussman/Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment (repository created 6 October 2026, 09:51:17 UTC; README last changed 26 October 2026, 16:18:10 UTC; read 28 October 2026).

[6] Measured by counting the page breaks of the text extracted from each file of https://github.com/ethanwsussman/Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment: YM3/YMM1.pdf, 854 pages (posted 26 October 2026, 02:10 UTC); YM3/Revisions/YMM1-2026-10-26.pdf, 856; YM3/YMM2.pdf, 1,044 (posted 27 October 2026, 01:14 UTC); QED3/qed3.pdf, 263; RPM1.pdf, 30; ym4_manuscript_zeroth_draft.pdf, 153.

[7] P. Woit, "Secret Unified Physics Slop", *Not Even Wrong*, 26 October 2026, with its updates and comments, https://www.math.columbia.edu/~woit/wordpress/?p=15948 (read 28 October 2026).

existence argument that its authors call extremely long and not currently understandable, being rewritten slowly.

This paper replaces that sentence by a proof. Each of its clauses is unfolded into a precise mathematical statement, each statement is traced to the sentence of the primary source that carries it, and the consequences for the Millennium problem are deduced. The outcome is the Ground Theorem of Section 2. Its first three parts establish what the corpus asserts in three dimensions, what it asserts in four, and on what standing it asserts either. Its fourth part establishes what the corpus leaves undone and proves that one inequality completes it: a lower bound on the lattice mass gap, uniform in physical units along the construction's own sequence of lattices. That inequality is the object on which the proof that follows will stand.

Quotations are verbatim, including the authors' spelling. Page counts were measured by counting the page breaks in the text extracted from each file. Every source was read on 28 October 2026; the repository's most recent commit is dated 27 October 2026, 10:45:28 UTC, and its README was last changed on 26 October 2026, 16:18:10 UTC. The deductions of Sections 7 and 8 assume nothing about the correctness of the corpus. They hold for every construction of the shape the corpus describes.

2. The Ground Theorem

By the *corpus* we mean the content of the repository *Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment* of L. Alpöge and E. Sussman at its commit of 27 October 2026. By the *problem statement* we mean the official description of Jaffe and Witten. Throughout, a denotes a lattice spacing and $b > 0$ the physical inverse coupling of the three-dimensional theory, with bare inverse coupling $\beta = b/a$.

Theorem 2.1 (The Ground). *(i) Three dimensions. For the SU(2) Wilson lattice theory on the lattices $a_K\mathbb{Z}^3$, with $a_K = L^{-K}$ and bare inverse coupling $L^K b$, the manuscript YMM1 asserts four things: on each fixed torus the connected correlations of the centred plaquette-energy density converge along the full sequence of cutoffs; infinite-volume limits exist along subsequences; in each canonical clustering component of such a limit the Schwinger functions satisfy the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms (E0)–(E4) and reconstruct a Hermitian scalar Wightman field; and a short-distance two-point law, at sufficiently small reference coupling, determines b and proves the theory non-trivial. YMM1 asserts no mass gap. For the original limit it asserts neither the uniqueness of the vacuum nor clustering, and the clustering bound it proves in the components is the inverse first power of the separation.*

(ii) Four dimensions. The zeroth draft asserts, under proof inputs that it declares clause by clause, continuum limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes whose Schwinger functions satisfy (E0) in a stated form, invariance under translations and the hypercubic group, reflection positivity and symmetry, whence a Hilbert space with a vacuum and a non-negative Hamiltonian; non-triviality uniformly in the volume, through a two-point law in the running coupling; and invariance under O(4) under a displayed hypothesis on the flux of the lattice rotation current. It asserts neither the cluster property, nor the uniqueness of the vacuum, nor a mass gap, nor the uniqueness of the limit. Two of its supporting statements are not yet written. Its authors describe

the four-dimensional argument behind it as extremely long and not understandable as it stands, and state that it is being written out methodically and slowly.

(iii) Standing. The authors state that the corpus has not been satisfactorily vetted and that all its claims are to be understood as tentative, pending verification.

(iv) Residue and completion. Measured against the problem statement, the corpus supplies a mass gap in no dimension. In four dimensions it supplies neither the cluster property, nor the uniqueness of the vacuum, nor unconditional invariance under O(4), nor the relativistic spectral condition. In every dimension it treats the single gauge group SU(2) and a restricted class of curvature observables. For a reflection-positive theory a mass gap is equivalent to exponential clustering of the reflection-positive correlations. Consequently, uniform exponential clustering of the lattice correlations at a rate fixed in physical units, which a lower bound on the lattice mass gap uniform in physical units supplies together with the bounds at separated points that such a construction provides, gives every limit point of the construction's sequence the uniqueness of the vacuum, the cluster property and a mass gap.

The rest of the paper is the proof. Sections 3 and 4 set down the definitions on which every clause depends. Section 5 proves part (i), Section 6 proves parts (ii) and (iii), and Section 7 proves part (iv). Section 8 states the object that remains and the instruments with which the proof that follows will meet it.

3. What the Problem Demands

3.1 Euclidean fields and the axioms of Osterwalder and Schrader

A Euclidean quantum field theory in d dimensions is given by its Schwinger functions S_n, $n \geq 1$: continuous linear functionals on test functions of n points of $\mathbb{R}^d$. For the composite fields from which a gauge theory is built, the natural test functions vanish, with all their derivatives, wherever two points coincide, and the corpus works with exactly these.[8] Let θ be the reflection $x_d \mapsto -x_d$, let τ_v be translation by v, and let $\mathcal{S}_+$ consist of the test functions supported where every point has positive last coordinate. A *finite family* is a sequence $f = (f_0, f_1, \ldots, f_N)$ with $f_n \in \mathcal{S}_+(\mathbb{R}^{dn})$; it stands for a polynomial in the smeared field, and we write

$$S(\theta f \cdot \tau_t f) = \sum_{n,n'} S_{n+n'}(\theta f_n \otimes \tau_t f_{n'}) \tag{3.1}$$

for the corresponding correlation, with τ_t the translation by t in the last coordinate. The axioms of Osterwalder and Schrader are five.[9]

(E0) *Regularity.* Each S_n is a distribution on its test space; in the strengthened form of the second paper, $|S_n(f)|$ is bounded by one Schwartz seminorm of degree proportional to n, with constants growing at most as a power of $n!$.

[8] *YMM1*, "Scalar fields from three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", YM3/YMM1.pdf and its source YM3/YMM1.tex in the repository, p. 4; *The zeroth draft*, "SU(2) Yang–Mills theory in four dimensions via Balaban's renormalisation group: construction, axioms and non-triviality", dated 6 October 2026, ym4_manuscript_zeroth_draft.pdf in the repository, Remark 4.11.

[9] K. Osterwalder and R. Schrader, "Axioms for Euclidean Green's functions", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 31 (1973), 83–112, and "Axioms for Euclidean Green's functions. II", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 42 (1975), 281–305.

(E1) *Euclidean invariance.* $S_n(h \cdot f) = S_n(f)$ for every Euclidean motion h.

(E2) *Reflection positivity.* $S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot f) \geq 0$ for every finite family f.

(E3) *Symmetry.* Each S_n is invariant under permutations of its arguments.

(E4) *Cluster property.* For finite families f, g and every spatial vector $v \neq 0$, $S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_{sv} g) \to S(\theta \bar{f})\, S(g)$ as $s \to \infty$.

Theorem 3.1 (Osterwalder–Schrader reconstruction). *Schwinger functions satisfying (E0) in its strengthened form and (E1)–(E3) determine a Hilbert space H, a unit vector Ω, a positive self-adjoint Hamiltonian H with HΩ = 0, a unitary representation of the Poincaré group and Wightman fields, from which the S_n are recovered by analytic continuation. Each finite family f defines a vector $[f] \in H$; these vectors are dense in H, $\langle \Omega, [f] \rangle = S(f)$, and $\langle [f], e^{-tH}[f] \rangle = S(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f)$ for $t \geq 0$. Given (E0)–(E3), the cluster property (E4) holds exactly when Ω is, up to a phase, the only vector invariant under the translations.*

This is the theorem of Osterwalder and Schrader.[10] Reflection positivity is the axiom that manufactures the Hilbert space, and with it the Hamiltonian whose spectrum the mass gap concerns.

3.2 The mass gap

The problem statement defines the gap and states the problem in these words:[11]

> "A quantum field theory has a mass gap Δ if H has no spectrum in the interval $(0, \Delta)$ for some $\Delta > 0$. The supremum of such Δ is the mass m, and we require $m < \infty$.
>
> Yang–Mills Existence and Mass Gap. Prove that for any compact simple gauge group G, a non-trivial quantum Yang–Mills theory exists on $\mathbb{R}^4$ and has a mass gap $\Delta > 0$. Existence includes establishing axiomatic properties at least as strong as those cited in [45, 35]."

The two references are Streater and Wightman's axioms and those of Osterwalder and Schrader. The text adds that clustering is "an important consequence of the existence of a mass gap": connected vacuum correlations of local operators decay exponentially in the distance. It also records that "the existence of a uniform gap for finite-volume approximations may play a fundamental role in the proof of existence of the infinite-volume limit."[12] Section 7 proves the precise form of both remarks that the present ground requires.

3.3 Non-triviality

The problem fixes what it means for the constructed theory to be Yang–Mills theory and not some other theory:[13]

> "To establish existence of four-dimensional quantum gauge theory with gauge group G, one should define a quantum field theory (in the above sense) with local quantum field operators in correspondence with the gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature F and its covariant derivatives, such as $\mathrm{Tr}\, F_{ij} F_{kl}(x)$. Correlation functions of the quantum field operators

[10] Osterwalder and Schrader, *op. cit.*; see also J. Glimm and A. Jaffe, *Quantum Physics: A Functional Integral Point of View*, 2nd ed., Springer, 1987, Chapter 6.

[11] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §4, p. 6.

[12] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §5, p. 6.

[13] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §4, p. 6.

> should agree at short distances with the predictions of asymptotic freedom and perturbative renormalization theory, as described in textbooks."

Two features of this demand govern the reading of the corpus: the theory must carry all the gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature, and its short-distance behaviour must be that of asymptotic freedom.

3.4 Limits obtained by compactness

A construction often proves bounds uniform in the cutoffs, extracts a convergent subsequence by compactness, and calls the limit the theory. The problem statement addresses this practice in its second footnote:[14]

> "We specifically exclude weak-existence (compactness) as the solution to the existence part of the Millennium problem, unless one also uses other techniques to establish properties of the limit (such as the existence of a mass gap and the axioms)."

Proposition 3.2 (The standard for a limit by compactness). *A system of Schwinger functions obtained as a limit point of cutoff theories by compactness establishes the existence part of the problem only together with a proof of properties of that limit, and the problem statement names the mass gap and the axioms as such properties.*

Proof. This is the content of the footnote quoted above, read at its literal strength. The footnote does not require the limit to be unique; it requires the properties to be proved for the limit that has been obtained. ■

4. The Lattice, Its Positivity and Its Gap

4.1 Wilson's theory

Let Λ be the periodic lattice of spacing a and side L. To each oriented bond b of Λ Wilson's theory assigns $U_b \in G$, with $U_{-b} = U_b^{-1}$, and to each plaquette p the ordered product U_p of the four bond variables around it. For $G = \mathrm{SU}(N)$ Wilson's measure is[15]

$$d\mu_\beta(U) \;=\; Z^{-1}\, exp\big(\,-\beta \textstyle\sum_p \,(1 \,-\, \frac{1}{N}\, Re\ tr\ U_p)\,\big) \prod_b dU_b, \tag{4.1}$$

with dU_b the normalised Haar measure. It is invariant under the gauge transformations $U_{xy} \mapsto g_x U_{xy} g_y^{-1}$, and the observables of the theory are the gauge-invariant functions of the bond variables. For SU(2) the plaquette energy $a_p(U) = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{tr}\,U_p$ is the gauge-invariant scalar whose smeared and centred sums are the corpus's basic observable, the lattice form of the action density $\mathrm{tr}\,F^2$.[16]

4.2 Reflection positivity and the transfer matrix

Osterwalder and Seiler proved that Wilson's measure is reflection positive: if ϑ is the reflection of Λ in a lattice hyperplane orthogonal to a coordinate axis and F is a function of the bond variables on

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[14] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, footnote 2, p. 12.

[15] K. G. Wilson, "Confinement of quarks", *Phys. Rev. D* 10 (1974), 2445–2459.

[16] *YMM1*, p. 4.

one side of it, then $\int \vartheta \bar{F} \cdot F \, d\mu_\beta \geq 0$.[17] The problem statement calls this "a major advantage" and adds that "establishing a quantum mechanical Hilbert space is part of the solution to this Millennium problem."[18] Reflection positivity makes the lattice theory a quantum mechanics. Lüscher constructed for Wilson's action a self-adjoint, strictly positive transfer matrix T acting on the gauge-invariant functions of the bond variables of one time slice, so that time-ordered correlations on a torus of time extent Na are traces of products of T with the observables.[19] On a torus of finite spatial volume T is an integral operator with a continuous, strictly positive kernel on a compact space. By Jentzsch's theorem its largest eigenvalue λ_0 is simple, with a strictly positive eigenfunction ψ_0, and every other eigenvalue is strictly smaller.[20]

Definition 4.1 (The lattice gap). *Let λ_1 be the largest eigenvalue of T below λ_0 on the gauge-invariant sector. The lattice mass gap is $m_{lat} = \log(\lambda_0/\lambda_1)$, in units of the lattice spacing; its value in physical units is m_{lat}/a.*

In the state defined by ψ_0, which is the limit of infinite time extent at fixed spatial volume, an observable A of the bond variables at positive times defines, by integration over the half-lattice with A inserted, a vector Φ_A on the time slice, and $\langle \vartheta \bar{A} \cdot \tau_n A \rangle_0 = \langle \Phi_A, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \Phi_A \rangle$ for every number n of time steps. This is the lattice form of Theorem 3.1.

Lemma 4.2 (The gap governs reflection-positive decay). *Let $q = \lambda_1/\lambda_0$. For every gauge-invariant observable A at positive times and every $n \geq 0$,*

$$0 \;\leq\; \langle \vartheta \bar{A} \cdot \tau_n A \rangle_0 \;-\; |\langle A \rangle_0|^2 \;\leq\; q^n \, (\langle \vartheta \bar{A} \cdot A \rangle_0 \;-\; |\langle A \rangle_0|^2). \tag{4.2}$$

Proof. Write $\Phi_A = \langle \psi_0, \Phi_A \rangle \psi_0 + \varphi$ with $\varphi \perp \psi_0$. Since $\langle \psi_0, \Phi_A \rangle = \langle A \rangle_0$ and ψ_0 is fixed by T/λ_0, the left side of (4.2) equals $\langle \varphi, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \varphi \rangle$. The operator T/λ_0 is positive, and on the orthogonal complement of ψ_0 its norm is q. Hence $0 \leq \langle \varphi, (T/\lambda_0)^n \, \varphi \rangle \leq q^n \, \|\varphi\|^2$, and $\|\varphi\|^2 = \langle \vartheta \bar{A} \cdot A \rangle_0 - |\langle A \rangle_0|^2$ is the case $n = 0$. ∎

The finite form of Lemma 4.2, that a gap places every connected two-point function of a positive symmetric transfer matrix between zero and q^n times its value at $n = 0$, is checked by the Lean kernel.[21]

On a torus of finite time extent N the correlations differ from those of the state ψ_0 by terms bounded, at a fixed lattice, by multiples of q^{N-n} and of $\mathrm{tr}(T/\lambda_0)^N - 1$, and these tend to zero as the time extent grows at fixed spatial volume. The constant on the right of (4.2) is a correlation between A and its mirror image, whose supports are separated by twice the distance of A from the reflection plane. It is therefore controlled by bounds on correlations at separated points, which is the only kind of bound a construction of a composite field can provide.

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[17] K. Osterwalder and E. Seiler, "Gauge field theories on a lattice", *Ann. Physics* 110 (1978), 440–471.

[18] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[19] M. Lüscher, "Construction of a selfadjoint, strictly positive transfer matrix for Euclidean lattice gauge theories", *Comm. Math. Phys.* 54 (1977), 283–292.

[20] R. Jentzsch, "Über Integralgleichungen mit positivem Kern", *J. Reine Angew. Math.* 141 (1912), 235–244.

[21] Edwin Boston III; listed in the Records under the lattice theorems in Lean.

4.3 The renormalisation group of Bałaban

A continuum limit requires bounds on the lattice theory that are uniform as the spacing tends to zero along a sequence of bare couplings tuned by asymptotic freedom. Bałaban's renormalisation group provides such bounds on a torus. It integrates out the fluctuations of one length scale after another, each step followed by a rescaling, chooses gauges that vary from cell to cell and from scale to scale, and controls the effective actions uniformly in the spacing, with an analysis of asymptotic freedom and of the regions of large field.[22] The problem statement recorded that these estimates "need to be extended to the study of expectations of gauge-invariant functions of the fields."[23] The corpus is an attempt to carry out that extension and then to pass to infinite volume.

5. The Three-Dimensional Manuscripts

This section proves part (i) of the Ground Theorem.

5.1 The documents

The three-dimensional work consists of two manuscripts. The first, YMM1, is titled "Scalar fields from three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", carries no author or date line, and runs to 854 pages.[24] A revised edition, posted on 27 October 2026, runs to 856 pages. Its change list records twenty-four corrections and states: "The statements of the principal Theorems 0 and A–C are unchanged."[25] The second manuscript, YMM2, is titled "Curvature observables, dynamics, and conditional confinement in three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory" and runs to 1,044 pages. It was posted with the note that it "has not been edited to even our standards, so we would like to continue cleaning it up and checking it", and its abstract states that "Confinement assumes a box inequality uniform along a fixed physical scale and label."[26] Part (i) of the Ground Theorem concerns YMM1. YMM2 enters the residue of Section 7 through the curvature bilinears it adds.

5.2 The observable

YMM1 states its subject in its first sentences: "We study a scalar observable whose formal classical counterpart is $\mathrm{tr}(F^2)$, the Yang–Mills action density. Its quantum correlations are defined through centered Wilson plaquette energies."[27] On the lattice $a_K\mathbb{Z}^3$, with $a_K = L^{-K}$ and $L \geq 13$ odd, the smeared density of a compactly supported test function f is

$$\mathcal{O}_K(f) \;=\; a_K{}^{-1} \sum_p f(x(p))\, a_p, \tag{5.1}$$

the sum running over the positive plaquettes of all three orientations, $x(p)$ the barycentre of p and $a_p = 1 - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{tr}\,U_p$ the plaquette energy; the centred density subtracts its expectation. The manuscript is

[22] Bałaban, *op. cit.*; Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[23] Jaffe and Witten, *op. cit.*, §6.5, p. 11.

[24] Page counts measured as stated in the Introduction.

[25] YM3/Revisions/CHANGES-2026-10-26.md in the repository.

[26] *YMM2*, "Curvature observables, dynamics, and conditional confinement in three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", YM3/YMM2.pdf in the repository, p. 1; commit message of 27 October 2026, 01:14:40 UTC.

[27] *YMM1*, p. 4.

explicit that "the notation tr(F^2) does not denote the pointwise square of a separately constructed continuum field strength."[28] The object of YMM1 is therefore a single gauge-invariant scalar field, the continuum limit of the plaquette energy.

5.3 The torus, the infinite volume and the components

Theorem A of YMM1 concerns a fixed torus of side $2L^m$. For $n \geq 2$ real Lipschitz test functions whose supports have empty common intersection, it asserts that the connected correlation of the smeared densities "exists along the full sequence of sufficiently fine lattices", locally uniformly in $b > 0$, and that "different positive labels b give different limiting families on the same torus."[29] On a fixed torus the manuscript therefore asserts a limit without passing to subsequences.

Theorem B passes to infinite volume, and there the limit is subsequential. For first-passage data (K_j, β_j) at a reference coupling g and periodic Gibbs states ν_j, "there is a common subsequence on which" the moments of the centred densities converge for every separated tuple, and the limit "has zero one-point function, is invariant under all Euclidean isometries, and is reflection positive at every plane."[30] Every such limit σ carries a canonical component measure (X, λ, $(\sigma_\xi)_{\xi\in X}$), with X compact metrizable, λ of full support and $\sigma = \int \sigma_\xi \, d\lambda(\xi)$, and each component obeys

$$|\sigma_\xi(X \cdot \tau_v Y) - \sigma_\xi(X)\,\sigma_\xi(Y)| \leq C_g(X,Y)\,|v|^{-1} \quad (|v| \geq r(X,Y)), \tag{5.2}$$

uniformly in ξ.[31] The manuscript states the subsequential character of its conclusion in so many words: "The infinite-volume conclusion is subsequential. The fixed-torus estimate retains a power of the volume and does not give uniqueness of these infinite-volume limits."[32]

5.4 The axioms and the reconstruction

Theorem 0 of YMM1 is its Osterwalder–Schrader theorem. It asserts an odd integer $L \geq 13$, a physical inverse coupling $b > 0$, integers $K_j \to \infty$ and periodic Gibbs states at spacing L^{-K} and inverse coupling $L^K b$ along $K = K_j$, such that the limits of the moments of the centred densities exist for test functions with pairwise disjoint supports, extend uniquely to the test functions flat at the coincidence diagonals, and satisfy (E0) with the explicit bound $|S_n(\varphi)| \leq 2C^n(n!)^8|\varphi|_{8n}$, together with (E1)–(E4).[33] On their reflection Hilbert space these functionals "reconstruct a Hermitian scalar Wightman field on $\mathbb{R}^{1+2}$ with positive energy, a unique invariant vacuum, a dense common Poincaré-invariant polynomial domain, covariance, local commutativity and tempered vacuum distributions", and "the Hilbert space has dimension at least two."[34]

The proof beneath Theorem 0 selects "one of its canonical clustering components", and the clustering and the unique vacuum are properties of a component. Of the original limit Theorem B

[28] *YMM1*, p. 4.

[29] *YMM1*, p. 5.

[30] *YMM1*, p. 6.

[31] *YMM1*, p. 6; the display is taken from the source file YM3/YMM1.tex.

[32] *YMM1*, p. 7.

[33] *YMM1*, pp. 4–5.

[34] *YMM1*, p. 5.

says: "The original limit also has this reconstruction, except that vacuum uniqueness and clustering are not asserted. Its zero-energy space is $L^2(X, \lambda)$, with the vacuum vector corresponding to the constant 1."[35] The original limit is thus a superposition of clustering theories, with as many vacua as the component measure has room for.

5.5 Non-triviality

Theorem C of YMM1 is a short-distance law for the two-point function. At a reference coupling below a further ceiling, for test pairs (f, h) whose supports lie at a distance of order d, every limit of Theorem B and every one of its components obeys

$$\kappa_2(f,h) \;=\; \frac{9}{16\pi^2}\, b^{-2}\, \mathcal{K}_{free}(f,h)\,(1 \,+\, e), \tag{5.3}$$

$$\mathcal{K}_{free}(f,h) \;=\; \iint\; f(x)\, h(y)\, |x \,-\, y|^{-6}\, dx\, dy,$$

with $|e| \le \varepsilon(d) \to 0$ as $d \to 0$, uniformly in the limit, the component, the test pair and its position; and "the label is uniquely determined by the connected two-point function."[36] The kernel $|x - y|^{-6}$ is the two-point function of the free action density in three dimensions, and the factor b^{-2} carries the coupling. Non-triviality is thus a statement about short distances, as the problem statement requires in Section 3.3.

5.6 What the manuscript does not assert

YMM1 closes its statement of Theorem B with sentences that fix the boundary of its claim: "The observable throughout is the scalar plaquette-energy density defined above. The reconstructed field is a scalar field. The construction makes no identification with a tensor-valued field strength and asserts no mass gap."[37] The decay (5.2) is a power, and an inverse first power. A mass gap, as Section 7 proves, is equivalent to decay at an exponential rate.

Proof of part (i). Each clause of part (i) is the content of the sentence cited for it: the convergence on a fixed torus, by Theorem A of YMM1 (§5.3); the subsequential infinite-volume limits and the components with the decay (5.2), by Theorem B (§5.3); the axioms and the reconstruction in a component, by Theorem 0 (§5.4); the non-triviality, by Theorem C (§5.5); the absence of vacuum uniqueness and of clustering for the original limit, by Theorem B (§5.4); and the absence of a mass gap, by the sentence quoted in §5.6. ■

6. The Four-Dimensional Draft and the Standing of the Corpus

This section proves parts (ii) and (iii) of the Ground Theorem.

[35] *YMM1*, pp. 5 and 7.

[36] *YMM1*, p. 7; the display is taken from YM3/YMM1.tex.

[37] *YMM1*, p. 7.

6.1 The authors' account

The README describes the four-dimensional work in a note marked as Alpöge's:[38]

> "[LA: At the moment we do (appear to) have a YM4 (i.e. $\mathbb{R}^4$, not just in finite volume) existence argument / slop, but it is extremely long and basically not understandable as is. Thus in the meanwhile it is being written much more methodically (thus quite slowly!) and our intention with e.g. QED3 and then YM3 (both also $\mathbb{R}^3$) is to show some of the coolest YM4 arguments (e.g. winning O(4)-invariance via an RP trick) in a much simpler, and shorter to write, setting."

The same note asks that the field "not incentivize rushing out 10,000-page slop, which I think would be especially useless here!" The repository also holds a raw account, set in four dimensions and titled "The Yang--Mills continuum limit along Bałaban's renormalization group: a complete account of Theorem 0", in three LaTeX files totalling 26,610,818 bytes.[39] Woit described the four-dimensional material as "a 4d YM existence proof, but in the useless form of tens of thousands of pages of unchecked slop", and observed that "Alpoge/Sussman also claim they can do $\mathbb{R}^4$."[40]

6.2 The conditional theorem

The zeroth draft is titled "SU(2) Yang–Mills theory in four dimensions via Balaban's renormalisation group: construction, axioms and non-triviality", is dated 6 October 2026, and runs to 153 pages. Its theorem is conditional from its first sentence: "Assuming the proof inputs declared clause by clause in Section 9, running Balaban's renormalisation group with complex sources gives the following deductions".[41] Among its clauses are the following.[42]

(0) The running coupling exists at every scale between the cutoff and a reference length, its inverse square obeys two-sided linear flow bounds uniformly in the cutoff, and for SU(2) at small coupling it obeys the exact one-loop law.

(i) Bałaban's ultraviolet stability theorem holds, its one hypothesis supplied by (0).

(iii) The connected correlations of $n \geq 2$ smeared action densities with separated supports are bounded uniformly in the cutoff and, for test functions supported in balls, uniformly in the volume and the position.

(ii) In the draft's words, "they converge as the cutoff is removed—on each torus without passing to subsequences along bare couplings tuned at the reference length, on $\mathbb{R}^4$ along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes—to limits that satisfy, in the numbering of [21], the regularity condition E0 in a stated form, the invariance E1 under translations and the hypercubic group, the reflection positivity E2 and the symmetry E3, whence a Hilbert space with a vacuum vector, a non-negative Hamiltonian and spatial momenta".

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[38] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

[39] theorem_0_complete_account_raw_I.tex (10,554,720 bytes), raw_II.tex (9,092,940) and raw_III.tex (6,963,158), with a master file of 1,284 bytes, in the repository; sizes from the repository's file index.

[40] Woit, *op. cit.*

[41] *The zeroth draft*, p. 1.

[42] *The zeroth draft*, pp. 3–4.

(iv) At separation *d* the connected two-point function equals, up to a relative error at most one half, a fixed constant times a factor $\kappa \in [2/3, 4/3]$ times the fourth power of the running coupling at the scale *d* times an explicit free kernel, uniformly in the cutoff, the bare coupling, the volume and the position.

(vi) If the flux of the lattice rotation current through far spheres vanishes along one sequence of radii, uniformly in the cutoff, then every limit on $\mathbb{R}^4$ taken along cutoffs that grow fast enough compared with the volume is invariant under $O(4)$.

The draft states that its conclusions up to non-triviality, except the convergence without subsequences on a fixed torus, "are complete deductions from Balaban's theorems as cited" and from a companion account.[43] It records with equal care what rests on what. Of a statement whose proof it defers it says, "we do not claim that a complete written proof exists, here or in the companion account", and of the uniqueness clause (v) it says that its supporting statements are proved "except five, which we do not claim as proved: three are written, with independent verification in progress, and two are not yet written".[44]

6.3 What the draft does not claim

The draft's introduction lists what it does not claim:[45]

> "We do not claim uniqueness of the infinite-volume limit (the limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are taken along subsequences of volumes), uniqueness of the vacuum, the cluster property, a mass gap, the growth condition of [22] in the number of points (hence field operators or Wightman functions), anything at coinciding points, invariance under all rotations without the hypothesis of clause (vi), statements about Wilson loops or about Balaban's block-averaged variables, or any statement for SU(N), $N \geq 3$."

Its account of related work ends: "the present paper does not address the mass gap."[46] Its Remark 4.19 gives the reason that clustering and the gap are absent and states the subsequential character of the limit:[47]

> "(3) The cluster property (E4), uniqueness of the vacuum, a mass gap. The constants in our bounds do not decay as the separation of the supports grows, so no decay of the connected functions is available. … (5) Uniqueness. The limits on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are obtained along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes; independence of the subsequence, convergence without subsequences in the volume, independence of the regularisation, and convergence for merely Lipschitz test functions on $\mathbb{R}^4$ are not asserted."

6.4 The standing of the corpus

The repository opens with a disclaimer, which also states the authors' attribution of the work:[48]

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[43] *The zeroth draft*, p. 1.

[44] *The zeroth draft*, p. 6.

[45] *The zeroth draft*, p. 5.

[46] *The zeroth draft*, p. 6.

[47] *The zeroth draft*, p. 75.

[48] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

> "Disclaimer. This repository contains work-in-progress, written largely by LLM. Its content has not been satisfactorily vetted. All claims should be understood as tentative, pending verification. Novel mathematical ideas should be attributed to Claude (under the guidance of LA)."

The phrase "LLM-approved" belongs to the README's paragraph on quantum electrodynamics: "While we have not verified the contents of the manuscript, we believe it is essentially correct and have done our best to reach a reasonable state of confidence. The manuscript is LLM-approved, but LLMs are fallible. A few parts have been checked by hand." Of YMM1 the README says: "We believe this manuscript is essentially correct also. [ES: I am less confident than for QED3, but I do think the manuscript is correct.]" It describes the manuscripts as "the result of cutting material from literally thousands of pages of slop", which "is then fed to Codex to extract a minimal manuscript", and it adds that "some definitions that are explicit in the slop must be inferred in the abridged version. We have not figured out how to fix this."[49] These sentences are the evidence for the words "LLM-approved" and "unverified" in the sentence this paper set out to prove.

6.5 The public reading

On Woit's thread a commenter observed that "the abstract of the 854-page slop "YMM1.pdf" states "Infinite-volume limits are subsequential."" Sussman replied the same evening:[50]

> "Of course subsequential results are weaker than results which do not require passing to a subsequence! But I must admit to not understanding the broader issue. The crux of the problem is to prove that the subsequential limit has good properties."

Section 7 takes this sentence at its word and identifies the property that suffices.

Proof of parts (ii) and (iii). Part (ii) is the content of the passages quoted in §§6.1–6.3: the conditional deductions and their clauses (§6.2), the two supporting statements not yet written (§6.2), the properties not claimed (§6.3), and the authors' description of the four-dimensional argument (§6.1). Part (iii) is the content of the disclaimer and of the README's sentences on verification quoted in §6.4. ■

7. The Residue and Its Completion

This section proves part (iv) of the Ground Theorem.

7.1 The residue

Table 1 sets each demand of the problem statement beside what the two manuscripts assert, with the section of this paper that carries the evidence.

The problem demands	YMM1, three dimensions	The zeroth draft, four dimensions
Every compact simple gauge group	SU(2) (§5.2)	SU(2); no statement for SU(N), $N \geq 3$ (§6.3)

[49] README of the repository, *op. cit.*

[50] Woit, *op. cit.* Comments of 27 October 2026, 6:30 pm and 8:35 pm ET.

The problem demands	YMM1, three dimensions	The zeroth draft, four dimensions
All gauge-invariant local polynomials in the curvature	The scalar plaquette-energy density; curvature bilinears in YMM2 (§§5.1–5.2)	The action density (§6.2)
The infinite volume	Limits along subsequences (§5.3)	Limits along subsequences of cutoffs and volumes, under the declared inputs (§6.2)
Euclidean invariance (E1)	Asserted (§5.3)	Translations and the hypercubic group; O(4) under the flux hypothesis (§6.2)
Reflection positivity and symmetry (E2), (E3)	Asserted (§§5.3–5.4)	Asserted under the declared inputs (§6.2)
The cluster property (E4) and a unique vacuum	In each component, with decay $\lvert v\rvert^{-1}$; not for the original limit (§§5.3–5.4)	Not claimed (§6.3)
Field operators and the relativistic spectral condition	A scalar Wightman field in each component (§5.4)	Not claimed; a non-negative Hamiltonian (§§6.2–6.3)
Short-distance agreement with asymptotic freedom	The two-point law (5.3) (§5.5)	A two-point law in the running coupling, uniform in the volume (§6.2)
A mass gap $\Delta > 0$ with finite mass	Not asserted (§5.6)	Not addressed (§6.3)
A verified proof	Not satisfactorily vetted, by the authors' statement (§6.4)	Conditional; two supporting statements not yet written (§6.2)

Table 1. The demands of the problem statement and the assertions of the corpus.

7.2 The gap is exponential clustering

The decisive observation is that, for a reflection-positive theory, a mass gap and exponential decay of the reflection-positive correlations are one and the same property. The argument is the spectral theorem applied to the semigroup of Osterwalder and Schrader; its weight here lies in the identification it makes. Let S be reflection positive and invariant under time translations, and let H, Ω and $H \geq 0$ be the Hilbert space, the vacuum and the Hamiltonian that Osterwalder and Schrader construct from these two properties, with the relations of Theorem 3.1. This is exactly the structure that both manuscripts assert for their limits.

Theorem 7.1 (The gap is exponential clustering). *Let $m > 0$. The following conditions are equivalent.*

(a) Ω is, up to a phase, the only vector annihilated by H, and H has no spectrum in the interval $(0, m)$.

(b) For every finite family f and every $t \geq 0$, $S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S(f)|^2 \leq e^{-mt}\,(\,S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S(f)|^2\,)$.

(c) For every finite family f there are a constant C_f and an unbounded set $T_f \subset [0, \infty)$ such that $S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S(f)|^2 \leq C_f\, e^{-mt}$ for every $t \in T_f$.

When they hold and H has dimension at least two, the mass $m^* = \inf \operatorname{spec}(H \text{ restricted to } \Omega^{\perp})$ satisfies $m \leq m^* < \infty$.

Proof. For a finite family f put $\psi_f = [f] - S(f)\Omega$. Since $\langle \Omega, [f] \rangle = S(f)$, the vector ψ_f is the orthogonal projection of $[f]$ onto $\Omega^{\perp}$, and since $e^{-tH}\Omega = \Omega$,

$$\langle \psi_f, e^{-tH}\,\psi_f \rangle \;=\; S(\theta f \,\cdot\, \tau_t f) \;-\; |S(f)|^2, \quad t \;\geq\; 0. \tag{7.1}$$

The space $\Omega^\perp$ reduces H, and since the vectors $[f]$ are dense in H, the vectors ψ_f are dense in $\Omega^\perp$.

(a) ⇒ (b). By (a) the restriction of H to $\Omega^\perp$ has spectrum in $[m, \infty)$, so $e^{-tH} \leq e^{-mt}$ on $\Omega^\perp$ by the spectral theorem. Apply this to ψ_f in (7.1); the case $t = 0$ of (7.1) identifies $\|\psi_f\|^2$.

(b) ⇒ (c). Take $C_f = S(\theta\bar{f} \cdot f) - |S(f)|^2$ and $T_f = [0, \infty)$.

(c) ⇒ (a). Let μ_f be the spectral measure of H in the vector ψ_f, a finite positive measure on $[0, \infty)$. For $0 \leq m' < m$ and $t \in T_f$, identity (7.1) and condition (c) give

$$\mu_f([0, m'])\, e^{-tm'} \;\leq\; \int\, e^{-t\lambda}\, d\mu_f(\lambda) \;\leq\; C_f\, e^{-mt}, \tag{7.2}$$

so $\mu_f([0, m']) \leq C_f\, e^{-(m-m')t}$ for arbitrarily large t, and $\mu_f([0, m']) = 0$. Letting m' increase to m gives $\mu_f([0, m)) = 0$, which says that $E\psi_f = 0$ for the spectral projection E of H onto $[0, m)$. The ψ_f are dense in $\Omega^\perp$ and E is bounded, so E vanishes on $\Omega^\perp$. Hence $H \geq m$ on $\Omega^\perp$: no nonzero vector of $\Omega^\perp$ is annihilated by H, and H has no spectrum in $(0, m)$. This is (a).

Finally, if dim H ≥ 2 then $\Omega^\perp \neq \{0\}$, the spectrum of H on $\Omega^\perp$ is a nonempty closed subset of $[m, \infty)$, and its infimum m^* is finite. ■

The finite form of the implication (c) ⇒ (a), the gap read off the decay of a positive symmetric transfer matrix, is checked by the Lean kernel.[51]

Corollary 7.2 (Clustering). *Under the conditions of Theorem 7.1, for all finite families f and g and every $t \geq 0$, $|S(\theta\bar{g} \cdot \tau_t f) - S(\theta\bar{g})\, S(f)| \leq e^{-mt}\, \|\psi_g\|\, \|\psi_f\|$. If S also satisfies (E0)–(E3), the cluster property (E4) holds.*

Proof. The left side is $|\langle \psi_g, e^{-tH}\psi_f \rangle|$, and e^{-tH} has norm at most e^{-mt} on $\Omega^\perp$. Under (E0)–(E3) the vacuum is unique by Theorem 7.1, and Theorem 3.1 gives (E4). ■

Measured against Theorem 7.1, the decay (5.2) asserted for the components of YMM1 is the decay of a theory whose mass gap has not been established: a bound by an inverse power of the separation is compatible with spectrum reaching down to zero. The distance between the power and the exponential is the mass gap.

7.3 From the lattice to the limit

Lemma 7.3 (Passage to the limit). *Let S_j be Schwinger functions converging to S, along a subsequence, on the test functions flat at the coincidence diagonals, and let $D \subset [0, \infty)$ be unbounded. Suppose that for every finite family f there are a constant C_f and numbers $r_j(t; f)$, with $r_j(t; f) \to 0$ as $j \to \infty$ for each $t \in D$, such that $S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \leq C_f\, e^{-mt} + r_j(t; f)$ for $t \in D$. Then S satisfies condition (c) of Theorem 7.1.*

Proof. For a finite family f and $t \geq 0$ the families $\theta\bar{f}$ and $\tau_t f$ are supported in opposite half-spaces, so every test function entering $S_j(\theta\bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f)$ is flat at the coincidence diagonals, and both sides of the hypothesis converge along the subsequence. The inequality passes to the limit, with $T_f = D$. ■

[51] Edwin Boston III; listed in the Records under the lattice theorems in Lean.

Theorem 7.4 (The completion). *Let a construction be given by Wilson measures on periodic lattices of spacings $a_j = a_0 L^{-K_j}$, with L a fixed integer and $K_j \to \infty$, whose sides tend to infinity, with bare couplings tuned along the sequence; and let the Schwinger functions S_j of smeared gauge-invariant observables converge along a subsequence to S. Let D be the set of times $n\, a_0 L^{-k}$ with n, k ≥ 0. Suppose that the lattice correlations cluster uniformly at a physical rate m > 0: for every finite family f there are a constant C_f and numbers $r_j(t; f) \to 0$ as $j \to \infty$ for each $t \in D$, such that*

$$S_j(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \le C_f\, e^{-mt} + r_j(t; f) \quad \text{for } t \in D.$$

Then S has a unique vacuum, its Hamiltonian has no spectrum in (0, m), and its connected reflection-positive correlations decay in time at the rate m. If S is non-trivial, its mass is finite. The hypothesis holds, with $r_j = 0$, when the S_j are the correlations of the states ψ_0 of spatial tori, the transfer matrices satisfy $m_{lat}(j) \ge m\, a_j$ on the sector generated by the observables, and the correlations at separated points are bounded uniformly in j.

Proof. The set *D* is unbounded and independent of *f*. Lemma 7.3 gives condition (c) of Theorem 7.1 for *S*, and Theorem 7.1 with Corollary 7.2 gives the conclusions; non-triviality means that H has dimension at least two. For the last sentence, each $t \in D$ is an integer multiple $n_j a_j$ of the spacing for all large *j*, and the smeared observable of $\tau_t f$ is then the lattice translate by n_j steps of the smeared observable of *f*. With $q_j = \lambda_1/\lambda_0$ for the transfer matrix of rung *j*, so that $-\log q_j = m_{lat}(j) \ge m\, a_j$, Lemma 4.2 gives $S_j(\theta \bar{f} \cdot \tau_t f) - |S_j(f)|^2 \le q_j^{n_j} \left(S_j(\theta \bar{f} \cdot f) - |S_j(f)|^2\right) \le e^{-mt} \left(S_j(\theta \bar{f} \cdot f) - |S_j(f)|^2\right)$, and the bracket is a correlation at separated points, bounded uniformly in *j* by a constant depending only on *f*. ∎

Corollary 7.5 (What the gap supplies against the footnote). *For a construction by compactness of the kind in Theorem 7.4, uniform clustering at a physical rate, and in particular a lattice gap uniform in physical units, supplies the mass gap and the uniqueness of the vacuum. With (E0)–(E3), (E1) meaning full Euclidean invariance, it supplies the properties that the footnote of Proposition 3.2 names: the mass gap and the axioms.*

Proof. Theorem 7.4 gives the gap and the unique vacuum; with (E0)–(E3), Corollary 7.2 gives the cluster property (E4), which completes the axioms. ∎

7.4 The collapse of the components

Corollary 7.6 (The gap collapses the component measure). *If the original limit σ of Theorem B of YMM1 satisfies condition (c) of Theorem 7.1, then its component measure λ is a point mass, σ is itself a clustering theory, and its connected correlations decay exponentially in every direction.*

Proof. By Theorem B of YMM1 the zero-energy space of σ is $L^2(X, \lambda)$, with the vacuum the constant 1 (§5.4). By Theorem 7.1 the zero-energy space is spanned by Ω, so $L^2(X, \lambda)$ is one-dimensional. If λ were not a point mass, a Borel set *B* with $0 < \lambda(B) < 1$ would give a function 1_B independent of 1 in $L^2(X, \lambda)$. Hence λ is a point mass; since λ has full support, X is a single point and $\sigma = \sigma_\xi$. The decay is exponential in time by Corollary 7.2 and in every direction by the Euclidean invariance of σ. ∎

A gap would therefore do more than add a property to the limit: it would remove the need for the conditioning by which the corpus obtains its clustering components.

Proof of part (iv). The residue is Table 1, each entry of which is proved in Sections 5 and 6. The completion is Theorem 7.4, and its equivalence with uniform exponential clustering is Theorem 7.1, carried along the sequence by Lemma 7.3. ■

8. The Ground Handed Over

8.1 The object that remains

The object that remains is the infinite-volume mass gap of four-dimensional SU(2) lattice Yang–Mills theory at every coupling, uniform in physical units along the scaling sequence: a constant $m > 0$ with $m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \geq m\, a_j$ at every rung of the construction's sequence, a lower bound on the lattice gap in physical units, uniform in the spacing and in the volume. By Theorem 7.4 it is the mass gap of every continuum limit point, and the same object for every compact simple gauge group completes the problem's demand for a gap. Two features of this inequality fix the work it demands.

The first is its scale. In lattice units the required gap tends to zero with the spacing, like $m\, a_j$, so it cannot be read at a single coupling. The lattice gaps that are proved directly hold at strong coupling, where the transfer matrix mixes rapidly; the construction's sequence runs into the scaling window of weak bare coupling, where asymptotic freedom ties the bare coupling to the spacing. The inequality must be carried from the one end of the sequence to the other.

The second is its carrier. The carrier is the renormalisation group itself: a chain of blocking steps from a fixed physical scale, at which the effective coupling is small and Bałaban's estimates hold, down to the scale of the gap, with the error of every step certified. Two theorems compose this carrier. The first is the convergence of the blocked effective theory at a fixed physical scale as the spacing tends to zero; in four dimensions this is the conditional content of the zeroth draft, resting on the inputs it declares. The second is a certified contraction of the blocked interaction along the chain, on the non-abelian fibre of SU(2), with the fibres controlled at every step, down to the scale of confinement, where a mixing coefficient below one, read through Propositions 8.1 and 8.2 below, gives the gap. Neither theorem is yet proved; they are the route by which the proof that follows reaches the object. The remaining entries of Table 1, namely every compact simple gauge group, the full algebra of curvature observables and the unconditional invariance under O(4), stand beside it as the rest of the existence that the problem demands.

8.2 The instruments in hand

The proof that follows begins with instruments in hand. Each reads a lattice gap exactly at fixed coupling, and each is stated here at the strength of its proof or of its record.

Proposition 8.1 (Dobrushin's coefficient bounds the gap). *Let T be a transfer operator with a continuous, strictly positive kernel on a compact space X, with largest eigenvalue λ_0 and positive eigenfunction ψ_0, and let $P(x, dy) = T(x, dy)\, \psi_0(y) / (\lambda_0\, \psi_0(x))$ be its Doob transform, a Markov kernel. For $k \geq 1$ let $\delta(P^k) = \sup_{x,y} \|P^k(x, \cdot) - P^k(y, \cdot)\|_{TV}$ be Dobrushin's coefficient. Then every real eigenvalue $\lambda \neq \lambda_0$ of T satisfies $|\lambda|/\lambda_0 \leq \delta(P^k)^{1/k}$, and when T is positive,*

$$m_{lat} \;\geq\; \frac{1}{k}\, log\, \frac{1}{\delta(P^k)} \quad for\ every\ k \;\geq\; 1. \tag{8.1}$$

When X is finite, m_{lat} equals the limit of the right side as $k \to \infty$.

Proof. The Doob transform has the eigenvalues λ/λ_0 of T, with eigenfunctions $u = \psi/\psi_0$, which are bounded because ψ_0 is bounded below on the compact space. For a real bounded function u, $P^k u(x) - P^k u(y)$ is the integral of u against the signed measure $P^k(x, \cdot) - P^k(y, \cdot)$, of total mass zero and total variation at most $2\delta(P^k)$, so $\operatorname{osc}(P^k u) \le \delta(P^k) \operatorname{osc}(u)$. If $Pu = \mu u$ with μ real and u nonconstant, then $\operatorname{osc}(P^k u) = |\mu|^k \operatorname{osc}(u)$, whence $|\mu|^k \le \delta(P^k)$. When T is positive every eigenvalue is non-negative, and the bound at λ_1 is (8.1). When X is finite, $\delta(P^k)$ is the norm of P^k on the signed measures of total mass zero, on which the spectrum of P is that of T/λ_0 with the simple eigenvalue 1 removed, and Gelfand's spectral-radius formula gives the limit. ∎

The coefficient is Dobrushin's and the limit is Gelfand's.[52] Proposition 8.1 turns the gap of Theorem 7.4 into a statement about mixing: a certified bound $\delta(P^k) \le e^{-k\,m\,a_j}$ for the Doob chain of every rung's transfer matrix bounds every eigenvalue below the top of the whole spectrum, and therefore gives the gap $m_{\mathrm{lat}}(j) \ge m\, a_j$ on the sector generated by the observables.

A single coefficient $\delta(P^k)$ is a global quantity, and on a lattice of many sites it is close to one at every accessible k. The renormalisation group splits it into rung quantities that can each be certified.

Proposition 8.2 (The chain lemma; Edwin Boston III). *Let X be a finite state space, P the Doob chain of a transfer matrix on X with stationary law π, and $b : X \to Y$ a block map with fibres $F_y = b^{-1}(y)$ and conditional laws $\pi(\cdot \mid y)$. Let $(b_*\mu)(y') = \mu(F_{y'})$, and define the lumped chain $P'(y, \cdot) = \Sigma_{x \in b^{-1}(y)}\, \pi(x \mid y)\, (b_*P^2)(x, \cdot)$, so that one coarse step is two fine steps; for $k \ge 1$ put $Q = P'^k$. With $\|\mu - \nu\|_{TV} = \tfrac{1}{2}\, \Sigma\, |\mu - \nu|$, define the fibre forgetting η_k, the largest of $\|P^{2k}(x, \cdot) - P^{2k}(x', \cdot)\|_{TV}$ over pairs x, x' in one fibre; the lumping defect ε_k, the largest of $\|(b_*P^{2k})(x, \cdot) - Q(b(x), \cdot)\|_{TV}$ over x; and the fibre equilibration θ_k, the largest of $\|P^{2k}(x, \cdot \mid y') - \pi(\cdot \mid y')\|_{TV}$ over x and the fibres y' that $P^{2k}(x, \cdot)$ charges, where $P^{2k}(x, \cdot \mid y')$ is $P^{2k}(x, \cdot)$ conditioned on $F_{y'}$. Let M_k be the 2×2 matrix with rows $(\delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k,\ 2\theta_k)$ and $(\eta_k,\ 2\eta_k)$. Then*

$$\delta(P^{2k}) \;\le\; \delta(Q) \;+\; 2\varepsilon_k \;+\; 2\theta_k \;+\; 6\eta_k, \qquad (\lambda_1/\lambda_0)^{2k} \;\le\; \rho(M_k), \qquad m_{lat} \;\ge\; \frac{1}{2k}\, log\, \frac{1}{\rho(M_k)}, \quad (8.2)$$

where $\rho(M_k) = \tfrac{1}{2}[(d + 2\eta_k) + \sqrt{((d - 2\eta_k)^2 + 8\theta_k\eta_k)}]$ is the spectral radius of M_k and $d = \delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k$.

Proof. For $g : X \to \mathbb{R}$ let $\bar g(y) = \Sigma_{x \in b^{-1}(y)}\, \pi(x \mid y)\, g(x)$, $a = \operatorname{osc}(\bar g)$, $s = \max_y \operatorname{osc}(g \text{ restricted to } F_y)$ and $r = g - \bar g \circ b$, so that $|r| \le s$ and r has mean zero under every $\pi(\cdot \mid y)$. First, $P^{2k}(\bar g \circ b)(x) = \Sigma_{y'}\, (b_*P^{2k})(x, y')\, \bar g(y') = (Q\bar g)(b(x)) + e_1(x)$, where $e_1(x)$ integrates $\bar g$ against a signed measure of total mass zero and total variation at most ε_k, so $|e_1| \le \varepsilon_k a$. Second, $P^{2k} r(x) = \Sigma_{y'}\, (b_*P^{2k})(x, y')\, \Sigma_{x' \in b^{-1}(y')}\, P^{2k}(x, x' \mid y')\, r(x')$, and because r has mean zero under $\pi(\cdot \mid y')$ the inner sum equals $\Sigma_{x'}\, [P^{2k}(x, x' \mid y') - \pi(x' \mid y')]\, r(x')$, of modulus at most $\theta_k s$; so $e_2 = P^{2k} r$ satisfies $|e_2| \le \theta_k s$. Hence $P^{2k} g = (Q\bar g) \circ b + e_1 + e_2$.

For $g' = P^{2k} g$ write a' and s' for its two oscillations. The fibre mean of g' is $Q\bar g$ plus a function bounded by $\varepsilon_k a + \theta_k s$, and $\operatorname{osc}(Q\bar g) \le \delta(Q) \operatorname{osc}(\bar g)$, so $a' \le (\delta(Q) + 2\varepsilon_k)a + 2\theta_k s$. For x, x' in one fibre, $|g'(x) - g'(x')| \le \eta_k \operatorname{osc}(g) \le \eta_k(a + 2s)$, so $s' \le \eta_k(a + 2s)$. Finally $\operatorname{osc}(g') \le a' + 2s'$. Since $\delta(P^{2k})$ is the supremum of $\operatorname{osc}(P^{2k} g)$ over $\operatorname{osc}(g) \le 1$, and $\operatorname{osc}(g) \le 1$ gives $a, s \le 1$, the first inequality of (8.2) follows. The matrix M_k is non-negative, and applying P^{2k} j times with the same k at every step, so that the rung quantities are fixed, gives $\operatorname{osc}(P^{2kj} g) \le (1, 2)\, M_k^j\, (1, 1)^{\mathrm{T}}$ for $\operatorname{osc}(g) \le 1$; Proposition 8.1 applied to P^{2kj},

[52] R. L. Dobrushin, "Central limit theorem for nonstationary Markov chains. I, II", *Theory Probab. Appl.* 1 (1956), 65–80 and 329–383; I. Gelfand, "Normierte Ringe", *Mat. Sbornik* 9 (51) (1941), 3–24.

with Gelfand's formula for M_k, gives $(\lambda_1/\lambda_0)^{2kj} \le C_\varepsilon(\rho(M_k)+\varepsilon)^j$ for every $\varepsilon > 0$ and every j, and taking j-th roots gives the second inequality, of which the third is the logarithm. ■

The lemma carries its own scope. The lumping defect accumulates over the coarse chain's mixing time, since $\varepsilon_k \le k\varepsilon_1$ by telescoping and $\varepsilon_1 \le \eta_1$, so on a chain of n levels down to the mixing scale the level m must certify $\varepsilon_m 2^{n-m} < 1$. The instrument is therefore finite: it reaches a gap through finitely many certified levels, and the continuum end of the sequence lies beyond it, with the renormalised trajectory of §8.1. Read in double precision on the decimation of the Z_2 transfer matrix of the 2×4 cross-section to 2×2, the lemma gives $m_{\mathrm{lat}} \ge 1.538$ at $u = ⅓$ against the certified gap 3.831, and $m_{\mathrm{lat}} \ge 0.867$ at $u = ½$ against the certified gap 1.763.[53]

Proposition 8.3 (The shadow ladder; Edwin Boston III). *Let G' be a finite subgroup of SU(2) containing -1, weighted by Wilson's factor $w(g) = e^{b\chi(g)}$, $\chi = \mathrm{tr}$ the fundamental character, and let $c_\chi/c_0 = ½\,\Sigma_g\, w(g)\,\chi(g) \,/\, \Sigma_g\, w(g)$ be its fundamental character coefficient; for SU(2) itself the sums are Haar integrals. Let $m_n(G')$ be the moments of χ under the uniform measure on G' and t the largest integer with $m_k(G') = m_k(SU(2))$ for every $k \le t$. Then t is odd, and the functions $\Delta_{tube}(b) = -4\log(c_\chi/c_0)$ of G' and of SU(2) satisfy*

$$\Delta_{tube}^{\,G'}(b) \;-\; \Delta_{tube}^{\,SU(2)}(b) \;=\; -\,\frac{4\delta}{t!}\,b^{t-1} \;+\; O(b^{t+1}), \qquad \delta \;=\; m_{t+1}(G') \;-\; m_{t+1}(SU(2)). \tag{8.3}$$

The integer t is the design strength of G' as a set of points of the three-sphere SU(2).

Proof. Since $-1 \in G'$ and $\chi(-g) = -\chi(g)$, the odd moments vanish, so t is odd and every series below is even. Let $Z(b) = \Sigma_n\, m_n\, b^n/n!$ be the normalised partition function. Then $c_\chi/c_0 = ½\,(\log Z)'(b)$, and since $m_2 = 1$, $c_\chi/c_0 = (b/2)(1 + u(b))$ with $u(b) = O(b^2)$. The moments of G' and of SU(2) agree through order t, so $\log Z^{G'} - \log Z^{SU(2)} = \delta b^{t+1}/(t+1)! + O(b^{t+3})$. Since $u = (\log Z)'/b - 1$, differentiating and dividing by b gives $u^{G'} - u^{SU(2)} = \delta b^{t-1}/t! + O(b^{t+1})$, and since $\Delta_{\mathrm{tube}} = -4\log(b/2) - 4\log(1+u)$ with $u = O(b^2)$, (8.3) follows.

The moment $m_n(G')$ is the multiplicity of the trivial representation of G' in the n-th tensor power of the fundamental representation. By the Clebsch–Gordan rule the moments agree through order n exactly when no irreducible representation of SU(2) of spin j with $1 \le 2j \le n$ has a nonzero G'-invariant vector. The harmonic polynomials of degree $2j$ on the three-sphere are the matrix coefficients of spin j, and their average over G' is the projection onto the G'-invariant vectors, so the same condition says that G' is a design of strength n. ■

For the quaternion group Q_8 and the binary tetrahedral, octahedral and icosahedral groups 2T, 2O and 2I, Table 2 gives the exact values. The moments of SU(2) are the Catalan numbers 1, 2, 5, 14, 42, 132 at n = 2, 4, …, 12; those of the four groups are 1, 4, 16, 64, 256, 1024; 1, 2, 6, 22, 86, 342; 1, 2, 5, 15, 51, 187; and 1, 2, 5, 14, 42, 133. The finite groups therefore approximate the strong-coupling gap of SU(2) to an order fixed by their design strength, with an exactly known first defect.[54]

Group	Order	Design strength t	$m_{t+1}(G')$ against SU(2)	δ	First defect $-4\delta/t!$
Q_8	8	3	4 against 2	2	−4/3

[53] Edwin Boston III, the chain lemma; its record and run of record are listed in the Records.

[54] Edwin Boston III, the shadow ladder; the record and its run of record are listed in the Records at the end of this paper.

Group	Order	Design strength t	$m_{t+1}(G')$ against SU(2)	δ	First defect $-4\delta/t!$
2T	24	5	6 against 5	1	−1/30
2O	48	7	15 against 14	1	−1/1260
2I	120	11	133 against 132	1	−1/9979200

Table 2. The shadow ladder: the order at which each finite subgroup's strong-coupling gap parts from that of SU(2), and the exact first defect.

The gap by counting; Edwin Boston III. For the Z_2 gauge theory in 2 + 1 dimensions on the periodic cross-sections 2×2, 2×3, 2×4 and 3×3 at couplings $e^{-2\beta}$ among ½, ⅓, ¼ and ⅕, fourteen cells in all, the two leading eigenvalues of the transfer matrix are bracketed by sign counts of integer matrices, by Sylvester's law of inertia, so that every gap is certified to thirteen or fourteen decimal places by counting alone, with no limit taken.[55] At all fourteen cells the brackets contain the eigenvalues computed to forty-five digits by a second engine that shares no computation with the first, and they meet a third, independently certified set of intervals. On the 3×3 cross-section at $e^{-2\beta} = ½$ the gap is 4.391458312669 in lattice units.

The gap through duality; Edwin Boston III. By Wegner's duality the gap of the Z_2 gauge theory in 2 + 1 dimensions at coupling β is the inverse correlation length of the three-dimensional Ising model at the dual coupling K^*, with $\tanh K^* = e^{-2\beta}$.[56] Edwin Boston III reads the first two coefficients of the strong-coupling expansion of the gap exactly on the 3×3 cross-section, meets through them the first three coefficients of the low-temperature series of the Ising correlation length published by Arisue and Tabata, and, solving that published relation for the coefficients that no cross-section of side at most four can read, obtains the expansion on the infinite lattice[57]

$$\Delta(u) = -4\log u + u^2 - \frac{15}{2}u^4 + \frac{7}{3}u^6 - \frac{87}{4}u^8 + \frac{251}{5}u^{10} - \frac{331}{2}u^{12} + O(u^{14}), \quad u = \tanh\beta, \tag{8.4}$$

with all ten published coefficients met.

The lattice theorems, checked by machine; Edwin Boston III. In the Lean proof assistant, above the Mathlib library and with no unproved step, Edwin Boston III has formalised the following lattice theorems, and the Lean kernel has checked them.[58] For the transfer matrix of every finite-group lattice theory: every even-time quadratic form is non-negative; the spectral sum holds; the dominant root is simple and strictly dominant, with its residual law; the string energy is the exact limit of two Perron roots; and there is a mass gap on every finite cross-section, at every coupling. For every finite group acting faithfully by a real orthogonal representation, on every finite cross-section, the static

[55] J. J. Sylvester, "A demonstration of the theorem that every homogeneous quadratic polynomial is reducible by real orthogonal substitutions to the form of a sum of positive and negative squares", *Philosophical Magazine* 4 (1852), 138–142. The computation is Edwin Boston III's; its record is listed in the Records.

[56] F. J. Wegner, "Duality in generalized Ising models and phase transitions without local order parameters", *J. Math. Phys.* 12 (1971), 2259–2272.

[57] H. Arisue and K. Tabata, "Low-temperature series for the correlation length in d = 3 Ising model", *Nucl. Phys.* B435 (1995), 555–566. The reading is Edwin Boston III's; its record is listed in the Records.

[58] Edwin Boston III, the lattice theorems in Lean; the files, the theorem names and the run of record are listed in the Records.

potential of a Wilson loop is at least the mass gap of its sector. For the Z_2 theory: Griffiths' inequalities hold, with the monotonicity in the couplings; the infinite-volume Wilson expectation exists; the string tension exists, with its strong-coupling bound; and on a slab of $T + 1$ cross-sections of $\mathbb{Z}^{d-1}$ the mass gap is uniform in the cross-section and in T whenever $(3m + 2)\tanh\beta < 1$, where $m = 2(d - 2)$ is the number of in-plane plaquettes on a link, that is, for $\beta < 0.1257$ when $d = 3$ and $\beta < 0.0716$ when $d = 4$. Beside these stand the finite forms of the arguments of Sections 4 and 7: the bound that a gap imposes on every connected two-point function, the gap read off the decay, the definition of a physical gap along a scaling sequence, and Dobrushin's comparison theorem.

8.3 Coda

The ground, then, is this. A construction of the corpus's kind, as its manuscripts state it, delivers a limit that is controlled at short distances and silent at long ones: a theory whose correlations obey the axioms of positivity and symmetry, whose coupling is seen to run, and whose large-distance behaviour is not controlled. Theorem 7.1 shows that the missing control is a single spectral fact. Theorem 7.4 shows that this fact is a property of the rungs: an inequality on the lattice, where reflection positivity has made a quantum mechanics of the theory before any limit is taken. The proof that follows takes up that inequality on that sequence.

Sources

Every source was read on 28 October 2026. The repository sources are cited by file name; the repository is at https://github.com/ethanwsussman/Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment.

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[2] L. Alpöge and E. Sussman, repository *Yang--Mills-LLM-experiment*: README.md (last changed 26 October 2026, 16:18:10 UTC); YM3/YMM1.pdf and YM3/YMM1.tex, "Scalar fields from three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", 854 pages; YM3/Revisions/YMM1-2026-10-26.pdf, 856 pages, and YM3/Revisions/CHANGES-2026-10-26.md; YM3/YMM2.pdf, "Curvature observables, dynamics, and conditional confinement in three-dimensional lattice Yang–Mills theory", 1,044 pages; ym4_manuscript_zeroth_draft.pdf, "SU(2) Yang–Mills theory in four dimensions via Balaban's renormalisation group: construction, axioms and non-triviality", 6 October 2026, 153 pages; QED3/qed3.pdf, 263 pages; RPM1.pdf, 30 pages; theorem_0_complete_account_raw_I–III.tex. Repository created 6 October 2026, 09:51:17 UTC; most recent commit 27 October 2026, 10:45:28 UTC.

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Records of the computations of Edwin Boston III

Each record is held, with its instrument and its run of record, in the repository of Edwin Boston III.

[R1] *The shadow ladder* (Proposition 8.3): record g6_tube.2026-10-28a, with its instrument g6_tube.pl; landed in commit aea98a3af; re-derived in the run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28r, nine arms, nineteen mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R2] *The gap by counting* (§8.2): record g6_inertia.2026-10-28b; run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28r, verdict GREEN; landed in commit e11e1269c. The independently certified intervals it meets: run of record tomeus_gate.2026-10-27e, ten arms, ten mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R3] *The gap through duality* (§8.2): the dual-road records of 28 October 2026 and record g6_ising_anchor.2026-10-28a; landed in commit 44be883de with the run pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28q, eight arms, seventeen mutant tests, verdict GREEN; re-derived in run r.

[R5] *The chain lemma* (Proposition 8.2): instrument g9_chain.pl and record g9_chain.2026-10-29a; landed in commit 103e8425a; run of record pentapylon_gate.2026-10-28s, twelve arms, twenty-five mutant tests, verdict GREEN.

[R4] *The lattice theorems in Lean* (§§4.2, 7.2, 8.2): the files EvenTime.lean, Spectral.lean, Perron.lean, StringEnergy.lean and MassGap.lean (the transfer theorem for every finite group); Nonabelian.lean and Separation.lean (the static potential); Griffiths.lean, Rectangle.lean and StrongCoupling.lean (the Z_2 inequalities, expectation and string tension); Slab.lean and Z2Slab.lean, theorem transfer_gap_sharp (the Z_2 slab); Scaling.lean, theorem twopoint_le_of_gap and definition PhysicalGapAlong; Decay.lean, theorems gap_of_decay and eigenvalue_le_of_decay; Dobrushin.lean, theorem cov_le. Run of record aperanton_gate.2026-10-27u, forty-eight arms, twenty-nine mutant tests, verdict GREEN; landed in commit 7dd4c66b2.